

“The Romans instil into their soldiers fortitude not only of body but also soul”

JOSEPHUS, *THE JEWISH WAR*, c.75CE

wars against the Numantines, in Spain, and against Jugurtha, King of Numidia, in North Africa. From 107BCE, the Roman general Marius instituted a number of reforms. The army became a permanent force, not recruited afresh each campaigning season, and it became open to all, rather than only the propertied classes. There was now just one form of heavy infantry, issued with standardized equipment – the *pilum*, the *gladius*, mail armour, and the *scutum*, a long rectangular shield. A more flexible tactical sub-unit – the cohort – also came into use. This consisted of 480 men, divided into six centuries (a unit of 80 men).

THE LEGIONS UNDER THE EMPIRE

The new army was supremely well-drilled and disciplined. It could advance to within 15m (50ft) of the enemy and would then let off a volley of

javelins and charge. Once at close quarters, the legionaries used their shields to strike enemies, then stabbed them in the stomach with their short swords. Highly trained, they were able to withstand a cavalry charge by using their javelins to form a type of phalanx (see pp.24–25). They rarely lost field battles against infantry forces, and their skill in siege warfare meant that only mobile opponents with strategic depth, such as the horse archers of the Parthian Empire, were able to fend them off. With back-up provided by professional auxiliaries – slingers, archers, and even specialist camel troops – armed with a wider range of weapons, the legions conquered much of Europe, North Africa, and the Middle East.

THE LATE ROMAN ARMY

Under the later empire, the Roman army became more diverse and was composed of smaller units. Smaller, oval or round shields were used instead of the *scutum* and lighter spears (*lancea*) replaced *pila*. Cataphracts (heavily armoured cavalry) came into service, and the army became more adapted to defending the Empire's frontiers, rather than engaging in aggressive field battles. An increasing reliance on foreign mercenaries – mostly Germanic – meant that, by the fifth century, the Roman Empire's western provinces had few military resources of its own able to hold back waves of barbarian invaders – a factor that contributed to the empire's fall in 476CE.



▼ ROMAN ARTILLERY

Roman legions carried field artillery with them. The bulk of these were ballistas – giant torsion operated machines that shot lead-tipped bolts.



KEY EVENTS

2600–750BCE

■ **264–241BCE, 218–201BCE, 149–146BCE** The Punic Wars between Rome and Carthage, in North Africa, end in a Roman victory. During the Second War, the Carthaginian general Hannibal crosses the Alps into Italy, defeating the Romans at Trebia and Cannae, but failing to capture Rome.

■ **102BCE** At the Battle of Aquae Sextiae, Roman general Marius defeats the invading Teutones, who threaten to overwhelm Italy. This is the reformed Roman army's first success.

■ **58–50BCE** Julius Caesar conquers Gaul, defeating numerous tribes and finally overcoming the resistance of the Gallic leader Vercingetorix at the decisive Siege of Alesia.

■ **27BCE** Augustus becomes the first Roman emperor. After a long period of civil war, he reduces the number of legions from around 60 to 28, all of which now pledge their loyalty to the emperor rather than to a variety of generals.

■ **101–02, 105–06CE** Emperor Trajan defeats the Dacian king Decebalus during the Dacian Wars. Dacia province becomes an outpost of the Roman Empire.

■ **378CE** Gothic barbarians defeat the main field army of the eastern Empire at the Battle of Adrianople. Emperor Valens perishes during the battle – Rome's worst military disaster for nearly 400 years.

◀ TRAJAN'S CAMPAIGN

A scene from Emperor Trajan's campaign against the Dacians, in 105–06CE, shows the Romans fending off an attack from a field fortification.